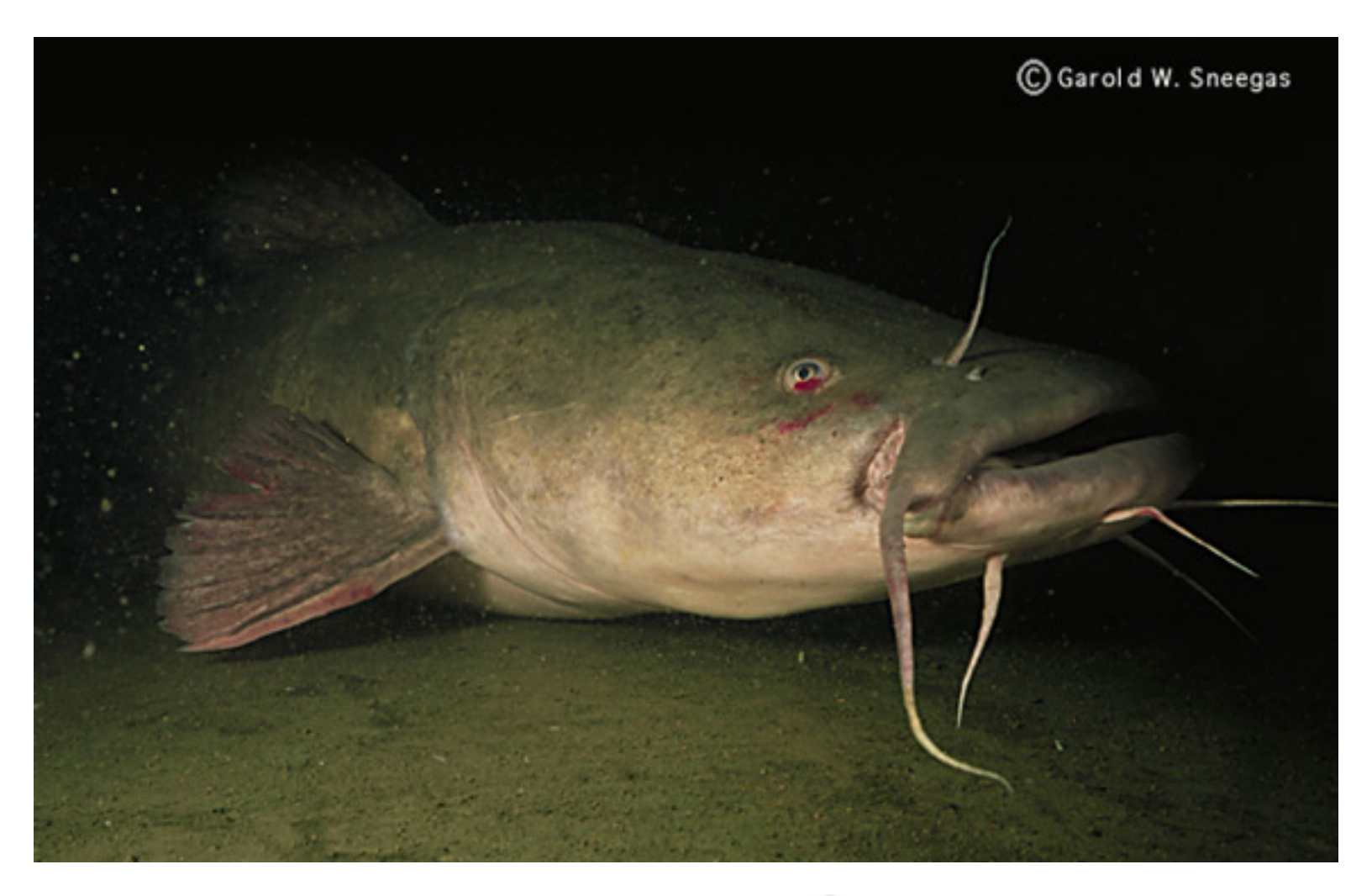
Pylodictis olivaris (Flathead Catfish)
Fishes
Native Transplant

Collection Info
Point Map
Species Profile
Animated Map
Impacts

Image 1 of 2



Garold W. Sneegas

Pylodictis olivaris (Rafinesque, 1818)

Common name: Flathead Catfish

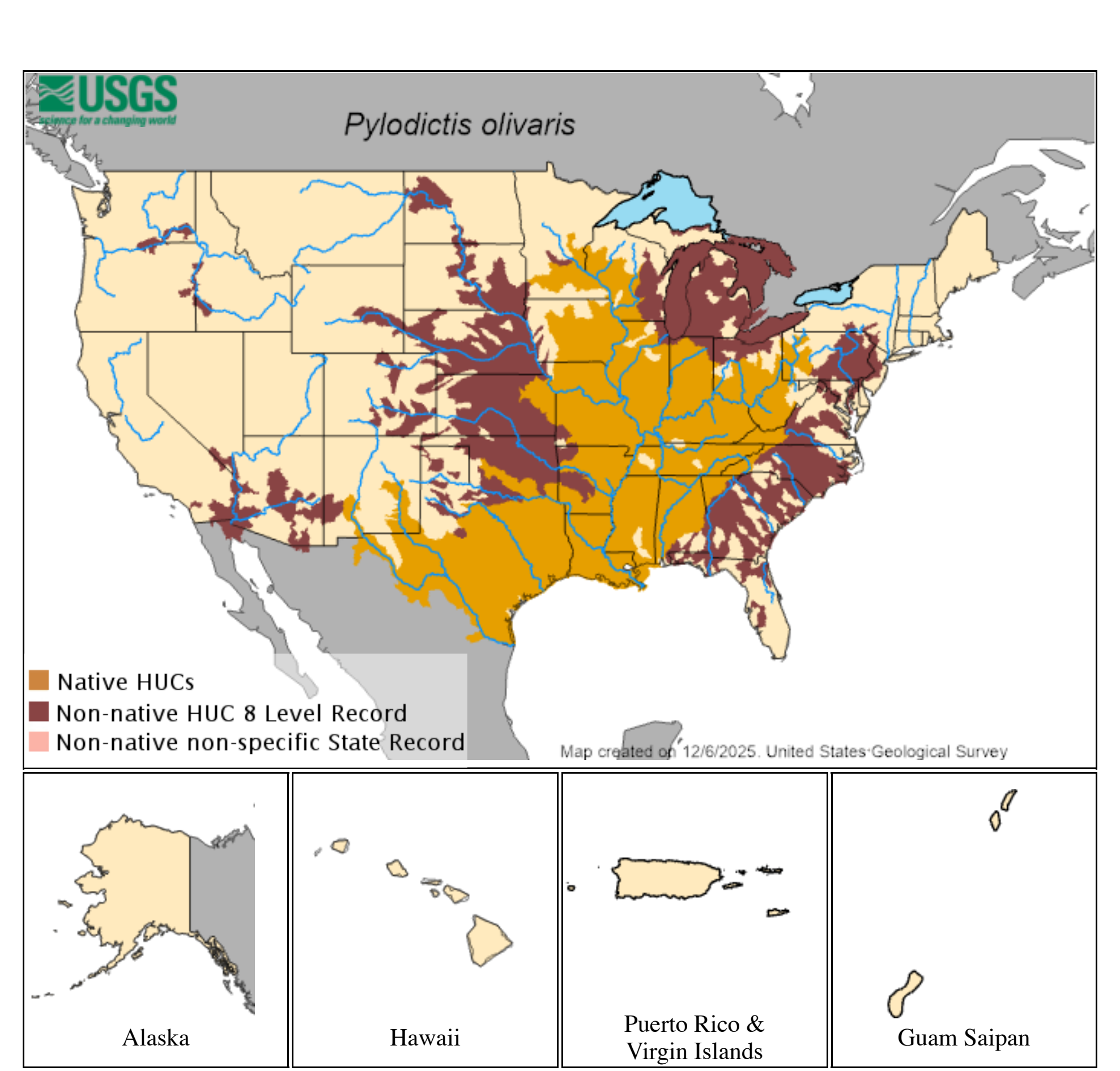
Synonyms and Other Names: mudfish

Taxonomy: available through ITIS

Identification: Wide, flat head - more so than native catfishes. Yellow to purple-brown dorsal coloration and pale white to yellow belly. Projecting lower jaw, pale tips on tail fin, short anal fin. Becker (1983); Page and Burr (1991); Etnier and Starnes (1993); Jenkins and Burkhead (1994).Projecting lower jaw, pale tips on tail fin, short anal fin. Becker (1983); Page and Burr (1991); Etnier and Starnes (1993); Jenkins and Burkhead (1994).

Size: 155 cm (Page and Burr 1991)

Native Range: Mississippi River basin from western Pennsylvania to White-Little Missouri River system, North Dakota, and south to Louisiana; Gulf Slope from Mobile Bay drainage, Georgia and Alabama, to Mexico (Page and Burr 1991).Mississippi River basin from western Pennsylvania to White-Little Missouri River system, North Dakota, and south to Louisiana; Gulf Slope from Mobile Bay drainage, Georgia and Alabama, to Mexico (Page and Burr 1991).


USGS
science for a changing world
Pylodictis olivaris
Native HUCs
Non-native HUC 8 Level Record
Non-native non-specific State Record
Map created on 12/6/2025 United States Geological Survey
Alaska
Hawaii
Puerto Rico & Virgin Islands
Guam Saipan

Native range data for this species provided in part by NatureServe
Hydrologic Unit Codes (HUCs) Explained
Interactive maps: Point Distribution Maps

Nonindigenous Occurrences:

Table 1. States with nonindigenous occurrences, the earliest and latest observations in each state, and the tally and names of HUCs with observations†. Names and dates are hyperlinked to their relevant specimen records. The list of references for all nonindigenous occurrences of *Pylodictis olivaris* are found here.

State	First Observed	Last Observed	Total HUCs with observations†	HUCs with observations†
AL	1996	2015	5	Lower Choctawhatchee; Lower Conecuh; Middle Chattahoochee-Walter F; Perdido; Upper Conecuh
AZ	1949	2023	17	Agua Fria; Bill Williams; Havasu-Mohave Lakes; Imperial Reservoir; Lower Colorado; Lower Gila; Lower Salt; Lower Verde; Middle Gila; San Francisco; Upper Gila-San Carlos Reservoir; Upper Salt; Upper San Pedro; Upper Santa Cruz; Upper Verde; White; Yuma Desert
AR	1940	2018	9	Beaver Reservoir; Fourche La Fave; Illinois; Ouachita Headwaters; Petit Jean; Poteau; Robert S. Kerr Reservoir; Upper Ouachita; Upper Saline
CA	1962	2014	5	Havasu-Mohave Lakes; Imperial Reservoir; Lower Colorado; Salton Sea; Santa Margarita
CO	1895	2015	9	Cache La Poudre; Middle South Platte-Cherry Creek; Purgatoire; San Luis; South Fork Republican; South Platte; Upper Arkansas; Upper Arkansas-John Martin Reservoir; Upper Arkansas-Lake Meredith
DE	2018	2020	2	Brandywine-Christina; Lower Delaware
FL	1950	2019	15	Apalachicola; Chipola; Escambia; Hillsborough; Lower Chattahoochee; Lower Choctawhatchee; Lower Ochlockonee; Lower St. Johns; Lower Suwannee; Peace; Pensacola Bay; Perdido; Santa Fe; Upper Suwannee; Yellow
GA	1950	2025	25	Altamaha; Altamaha; Little; Lower Chattahoochee; Lower Flint; Lower Ochlockonee; Lower Ocmulgee; Lower Oconee; Lower Ogeechee; Middle Chattahoochee-Lake Harding; Middle Chattahoochee-Walter F; Middle Flint; Middle Savannah; Ogeechee Coastal; Ohoopee; Satilla; Savannah; Spring; Tugaloo; Upper Chattahoochee; Upper Flint; Upper Ochlockonee; Upper Ocmulgee; Upper Oconee; Upper Savannah
ID	1943	2015	2	Brownlee Reservoir; Middle Snake-Payette
IL	2010	2011	3	Chicago; Des Plaines; Little Calumet-Galien
IN	2010	2010	1	Little Calumet-Galien
IA	1940	2002	3	Blackbird-Soldier; Lower Big Sioux; Missouri-Little Sioux
KS	1910	2017	56	Arkansas-Dodge City; Arkansas-White-Red Region; Big; Big Nemaha; Buckner; Caney; Chikaskia; Coon-Pickerel; Cow; Crooked; Elk; Fall; Gar-Peace; Hackberry; Kaw Lake; Little Arkansas; Lower Big Blue; Lower Cottonwood; Lower Little Blue; Lower North Fork Solomon; Lower Republican; Lower Saline; Lower Salt Fork Arkansas; Lower Smoky Hill; Lower South Fork Solomon; Lower Walnut Creek; Lower Walnut River; Medicine Lodge; Middle Arkansas; Middle Arkansas-Slate; Middle Neosho; Middle Republican; Middle Smoky Hill; Middle Verdigris; Neosho Headwaters; Ninnescah; North Fork Ninnescah; Pawnee; Prairie Dog; Rattlesnake; Smoky Hill; Solomon; South Fork Beaver; South Fork Ninnescah; Spring; Tarkio-Wolf; Upper Cimarron; Upper Cimarron-Bluff; Upper Cottonwood; Upper Neosho; Upper North Fork Solomon; Upper Saline; Upper Smoky Hill; Upper South Fork Solomon; Upper Verdigris; Upper Walnut River
MD	2002	2024	5	Chester-Sassafras; Conococheague-Opequon; Lower Susquehanna; Middle Potomac-Catoctin; Upper Chesapeake Bay
MI	1922	2025	28	Au Sable; Betsy-Chocolay; Black-Macatawa; Boardman-Charlevoix; Cass; Clinton; Detroit; Flint; Kalamazoo; Kawkawlin-Pine; Lake Erie; Lake Huron; Lake Michigan; Lake St. Clair; Lower Grand; Manistee; Maple; Muskegon; Pere Marquette-White; Saginaw; Shiawassee; St. Clair; St. Joseph; St. Joseph; Thornapple; Thunder Bay; Tittabawassee; Upper Grand
MN	1978	2001	2	Crow; Upper Mississippi-Crow-Rum
MO	2006	2006	1	Spring
NE	1926	2017	38	Big Nemaha; Big Papillion-Mosquito; Blackbird-Soldier; Calamus; Frenchman; Harlan County Reservoir; Keg-Weeping Water; Lewis and Clark Lake; Little Nemaha; Logan; Loup; Lower Elkhorn; Lower Little Blue; Lower Middle Loup; Lower Niobrara; Lower North Loup; Lower North Platte; Lower Platte; Lower Platte-Shell; Lower South Platte; Medicine; Middle Big Blue; Middle Platte-Buffalo; Middle Platte-Prairie; Middle Republican; Red Willow; Salt; South Fork Big Nemaha; South Loup; Tarkio-Wolf; Turkey; Upper Big Blue; Upper Elkhorn; Upper Little Blue; Upper Niobrara; Upper Republican; West Fork Big Blue; Wood
NV	2007	2007	1	Ivanpah-Pahrump Valleys
NJ	1999	2020	4	Crosswicks-Neshaminy; Middle Delaware-Mongaup-Brodhead; Middle Delaware-Musconetcong; Raritan
NM	1949	2015	3	San Francisco; Upper Gila; Upper Gila-Mangas
NY	2011	2011	1	Upper Delaware
NC	1965	2019	27	Black; Cape Fear; Contentnea; Deep; Haw; Lower Cape Fear; Lower Dan; Lower Neuse; Lower Pee Dee; Lower Tar; Lower Yadkin; Lumber; Middle Neuse; Northeast Cape Fear; Pamlico; Roanoke Rapids; Rocky; Upper Cape Fear; Upper Catawba; Upper Dan; Upper Neuse; Upper Pee Dee; Upper Pee Dee; Upper Tar; Upper Yadkin; Waccamaw; White Oak River
ND	1973	2016	3	Lake Sakakawea; Lower Little Missouri; Upper Lake Oahe
OH	1890	2021	12	Ashtabula-Chagrin; Auglaize; Black-Rocky; Cedar-Portage; Cuyahoga; Huron-Vermilion; Lake Erie; Lower Maumee; Sandusky; St. Marys; Tiffin; Upper Maumee
OK	1946	2021	39	Bird; Black Bear-Red Rock; Blue-China; Cache; Caney; Chikaskia; Deep Fork; Dirty-Greenleaf; Farmers-Mud; Illinois; Kaw Lake; Kiamichi; Lake O' The Cherokees; Lake Texoma; Little; Lower Beaver; Lower Canadian; Lower Canadian-Deer; Lower Canadian-Walnut; Lower Cimarron; Lower Cimarron-Eagle Chief; Lower Cimarron-Skeleton; Lower Neosho; Lower North Canadian; Lower North Fork Red; Lower Salt Fork Arkansas; Lower Verdigris; Lower Wolf; Medicine Lodge; Middle North Canadian; Middle Verdigris; Neosho; Northern Beaver; Polecat-Snake; Poteau; Robert S. Kerr Reservoir; Spring; Upper Cimarron; West Cache
OR	1975	2015	5	Brownlee Reservoir; Lower Malheur; Middle Columbia-Lake Wallula; Middle Snake-Payette; Middle Snake-Succor
PA	1991	2025	14	Crosswicks-Neshaminy; Lehigh; Lower Delaware; Lower Juniata; Lower Susquehanna; Lower Susquehanna-Penns; Lower Susquehanna-Swatara; Lower West Branch Susquehanna; Middle Delaware-Musconetcong; Owego-Wappasening; Raystown; Schuylkill; Upper Susquehanna-Lackawanna; Upper Susquehanna-Tunkhannock
SC	1964	2018	22	Carolina Coastal-Sampit; Congaree; Cooper; Edisto River; Lake Marion; Little Pee Dee; Lower Broad; Lower Pee Dee; Lower Pee Dee; Lynches; Middle Savannah; North Fork Edisto; Salkehatchie; Saluda; Santee; Santee; Seneca; South Fork Edisto; Tugaloo; Upper Savannah; Waccamaw; Wateree
SD	1896	2018	8	Fort Randall Reservoir; Lewis and Clark Lake; Lower Big Sioux; Lower James; Lower Lake Oahe; Lower White; Middle James; Vermillion
TX	1953	2018	13	Double Mountain Fork Brazos; Lake Meredith; Little Wichita; Lower Colorado-Cummins; North Fork Double Mountain Fork Brazos; North Wichita; Pease; Rita Blanca; Tule; Upper Colorado; Upper Salt Fork Red; White; Wichita
VA	1965	2015	12	Banister; Lower Dan; Lower James; Mattaponi; Middle James-Buffalo; Middle James-Willis; Middle Potomac-Anacostia-Occoquan; Middle Roanoke; Pamunkey; Roanoke; Upper James; Upper Roanoke
WA	1978	1978	2	Lower Snake; Lower Snake-Tucannon
WI	1923	2017	9	Lake Michigan; Lake Winnebago; Lower Fox; Middle Rock; Milwaukee; Upper Fox; Upper Fox; Upper Rock; Wolf
WY	1993	2004	3	Glendo Reservoir; Middle North Platte-Casper; Middle North Platte-Scotts Bluff

Table last updated 12/8/2025

† Populations may not be currently present.

Ecology: *Pylodictis olivaris* is found in large rivers, streams, and lakes, usually over hard bottoms. They prefer deep, sluggish pools, with logs and other submerged debris that can be used as cover. Young *P. olivaris* live in rocky or sandy runs in the river and in riffles, often under stones on riffles (Hubbs and Lagler 2004; Page and Burr 2011). This species lives in shallower (<3 m) waters in summer/at night and migrates to deeper waters (> 4m) in the day/winter (Daugherty and Sutton 2005). This species benefits from turbid waters as they are a non-sight feeding predator (Ward and Vaage 2019).

Unlike other catfish, Flathead Catfish feed on only live prey. Adult Flathead Catfish are piscivorous ambush predators (Eggleton and Schramm 2004). This species has a diverse diet, feeding on macroinvertebrates and fish, including shads, centrarchids, bass, and crayfish (Schmitt et al. 2019; Montague and Shoup 2021).

Age at sexual maturity appears to be regionally dependent, ranging from 3–5 years for males and 3–7 years for females. Spawning occurs once in late spring to early summer when water temperatures reach 19 to 24 degrees Celsius. One or both parents excavate a nest that is usually made in a natural cavity or near a large submerged object (Jackson 1999). Females lay a mass of up to 100,000 adhesive eggs (Jackson 1999), or 1,637 to 5,025 eggs/kg (Gima 2009). Males guard the nest and agitate the eggs to keep them clean and aerated. The young remain in a school near the nest for several days after hatching, but soon disperse. Flathead Catfish can live up to 28 years (Jackson 1999).

Means of Introduction: The Flathead Catfish has been intentionally stocked in most cases. In Idaho, however, flatheads were accidentally stocked instead of blue catfish (Simpson and Wallace 1978). Populations in the Apalachicola River, Florida, probably spread from introductions upstream in the Flint River, Georgia. It is believed that flatheads were stocked by anglers circa 1950 in the vicinity of Potato Creek in Upson County, Georgia, with stock from the Tennessee drainage (Quinn 1988). They were recorded in the Flint River below the Warwick Dam at Lake Blackshear in the early 1960s, and at Albany in the early 1970s (Quinn 1988). The species was apparently first stocked in the Cape Fear River in 1966 when 11 sexually mature fish were released near Fayetteville, North Carolina, by North Carolina Wildlife Resources Commission biologists (Guire et al. 1984; Ashley and Buff 1986). Flatheads were stocked in Atlantic drainages (Savannah and Altamaha) in Georgia in the 1970s (Bart et al. 1994; C. Jennings, personal communication). According to Bart et al. (1994), at least some of these were the result of stocking by Georgia Department of Natural Resource personnel. The first known reports of this fish in California were recorded catches made in the lower Colorado River near Yuma in 1966 (Dill and Cordone 1997). The Colorado River populations in California and Arizona resulted, at least in part, from a stocking of about 600 Flathead Catfish above Imperial Dam made by the Arizona Game and Fish Department in 1962 (Dill and Cordone 1997). According to Dill and Cordone (1997), the believed route of the Flathead Catfish was downstream to Imperial Dam and subsequently into the All American Canal system to the Imperial Valley. Minckley (1973) reported that the species was introduced prior to 1950 into the Gila River system, a tributary of the Colorado River; however, Dill and Cordone (1997) indicated that the Flathead Catfish was not taken in the lower Colorado River basin until after 1962. A single fish was taken 20 November 1995 in Arizona from the upper San Pedro River, about 32 kilometers from the Mexican border (S. Stefferud, personal communication). It is not known how the species gained access to the upper reach of this river. In Wisconsin, flatheads probably entered the Wolf and Fox drainages via the canal at Portage (Becker 1983). The Ochlockonee River introduction in Florida and Georgia was probably due to illegal stocking by anglers with fish from the nearby Apalachicola River, where the fish had also been introduced. The flathead's presence in eastern Pennsylvania is most likely due to stock contamination of channel catfish shipments (M. Kaufman, personal communication).

Status: Occurs in all U.S. states except Alaska, Hawaii, Montana, Utah and the New England states (Montague and Shoup 2021). The Flathead Catfish has become established in most waters where introduced. For instance, it is widespread and reproducing in the lower Colorado River basin (Dill and Cordone 1997). As of about 1980, the Cape Fear River population had expanded from the site of its initial release near Fayetteville, North Carolina, and was found to inhabit a 201-kilometer stretch of the river (Guire et al. 1984). In samples taken by Guire et al. (1984) from the Cape Fear River, flathead accounted for 10.52% of total fish numbers and 64.7% of total fish weight. Establishment in Oregon is uncertain (Bond 1994). The species does not appear to have survived to reproduce in Wyoming (Hubert 1994). It has been reported from the San Pedro River, Arizona, and from the Suwannee River, Florida. Established in Blue Marsh Reservoir and the Schuylkill River in Pennsylvania; reported in Springton Reservoir, Pennsylvania.

Great Lakes: Reproducing and overwintering in Lakes Erie, Huron, and Michigan.

Impact of Introduction:

Summary of species impacts derived from literature review. Click on an icon to find out more...

Ecological | **Economic** | **Human Health** | **Other**

Many feeding studies have found that Flathead Catfish prey heavily on sunfish *Lepomis* spp. (Quinn 1988). One study found that they reduced the number of common carp *Cyprinus carpio* and bullheads *Ameiurus* spp. (Quinn 1988). However, the introduced population in the Flint River system was found to prey largely on crayfish, and that young-of-the-year flatheads fed on darters *Etheostoma* spp. clupeids, catostomids, ictalurids (including other flatheads), and centrarchids were also consumed (Quinn 1988). According to Quinn (1988), introduced flatheads in the Flint River rely more on crayfish than any other catfish population yet described. A severe decline in native fish species, particularly native bullhead species, was observed in the Cape Fear River within 15 years of the first Flathead Catfish introduction (Guire et al. 1984; Jenkins and Burkhead 1994). Feeding studies conducted in the Cape Fear River showed that flatheads consume mainly bullheads, catfishes, shad, and sunfishes (Guire et al. 1984; Ashley and Buff 1986). In 1979, flatheads in the Cape Fear River fed primarily on bullheads. However, by 1986, bullhead populations had declined and Flathead Catfish had switched to preying on shad (Ashley and Buff 1986). Diet studies also have been conducted in the Oconee River in Georgia, where this catfish had been implicated in causing declines of native bullheads and sunfishes (especially redbreast sunfish *Lepomis auritus*). However, findings of that initial study were inconclusive since most of the Flathead Catfish examined had empty stomachs (C. Jennings, personal communication). Flathead Catfish also may be responsible for declines in other native species in the Altamaha drainage (C. Jennings, personal communication). In the Ocmulgee River, Georgia, abundances of silver redhorse *Moxostoma anisurum*, robust redhorse *M. robustum*, snail bullhead *Ameiurus brunneus*, flat bullhead *A. platycephalus*, and redbreast sunfish *Lepomis auritus*, were negatively correlated with Flathead Catfish occurrence and abundance (Bart et al. 1994). This correlation may be due to direct predation. Several authors have reported suckers and catfish as common prey items of flatheads (Bart et al. 1994). The snail bullhead and flat bullhead appear to be most affected by the presence of Flathead Catfish in the Ocmulgee drainage (Bart et al. 1994). It is suspected flatheads may be contributing to the decline of the federally threatened Gulf sturgeon *Acipenser oxyrinchus desotoi* by consuming the young benthic fish in the Apalachicola River (J. Williams, personal communication). The Flathead Catfish is thought to be contributing to the decline of the razorback sucker *Xyrauchen texanus*. For instance, Marsh and Brooks (1989) found that intensive predation by Flathead Catfish and channel catfish on juvenile razorback suckers is likely to prevent hatchery transplants of this southwestern endangered sucker from becoming re-established in portions of its natural range. If the Flathead Catfish becomes established in the San Pedro River, it could mean a major loss for recovery of several species (S. Stefferud, personal communication). Introductions of Flathead Catfish are probably the most biologically harmful of all fish introductions in North America (C. Gilbert, personal communication). Flathead Catfish, along with other nonnative piscivorous fishes, have been shown to reduce the abundance and diversity of native prey species in several Pacific Northwest rivers (Hughes and Herlihy 2012).

Remarks: The Flathead Catfish became the dominant predator in the Cape Fear drainage of North Carolina within 15 years of the introduction (Guire et al. 1984). The species may actually be native to the upper Tennessee drainage in North Carolina (Jenkins and Starnes, personal communication). In their book on Alabama fishes, Mettee et al. (1996) presented conflicting information regarding native versus introduced ranges. These researchers stated, in the species account, that *Pylodictis olivaris* is introduced to the Conecuh and Escatawpa river systems, but they listed the species as "native" in their summary table. Starnes et al. (2011) suggest that although the Potomac River population is highly localized, favorable habitat in the Plummers Island area could allow it to expand further upstream.

Flathead Catfish was previously suggested as native to the lower Great Lakes (Underhill 1986; Bailey et al. 2004); however, Fuller and Whelan (2018) provided historical evidence for its absence from the basin. University of Michigan voucher specimens are in Bailey et al. (2004) for two tributaries in southern Michigan. A single specimen was caught in the Canadian waters of western Lake Erie in 1978 by a commercial fisherman. This specimen was deposited in the Royal Ontario Museum collection (Crossman and Leach 1979). Despite the fact that Wydoski and Whitney (2003) say Flathead Catfish were in the lower Snake and Columbia rivers by the mid 1970s, neither the regional fishery biologist for that area, nor the warmwater fisheries manager for the state have ever seen or heard of one in the state (Chris Donnelly and Bruce Bolding, Washington Department of Fish and Wildlife, personal communication 1/6/2016, 1/7/2016). Although there is a supposed Washington State Record fish (22.8 lbs from the Snake River in 1981 (WDFW 2021), Bolding believes this was a misidentified Channel Catfish.

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Other Resources:
Flathead catfish at the Fort Worth Zoo

Pennsylvania's flathead info - Pennsylvania Fish and Boat Commission

Pylodictis olivaris (Global Invasive Species Database)

Great Lakes Waterlife

US Fish and Wildlife Service Ecological Risk Screening Summary for *Pylodictis olivaris*

FishBase Summary

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